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Tom Lellis

Tom Lellis has developed multiple skills throughout his career in music. He started as a stand-up singer at age 15 and today is noted as an accomplished lyricist, composer, instrumentalist and an artist who has found his own signature sound. Tom's recordings and original compositions have been praised by DownBeat, JazzIz *and the International Association of Jazz Educators.*

Tom was interviewed in Clinton, New York on July 31, 2007 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are at Hamilton College filming for the Jazz Archive, and I'm very pleased to have Tom Lellis with me today. And I was trying to figure out how to introduce you, as to what you do. You do a lot of things. But I saw on your website, you said, "Singer, composer and instrumentalist." So that pretty much —

TL: That pretty much sums it up.

MR: Most of it.

TL: Yeah.

MR: Do you think of yourself first as one of those?

TL: I think first of myself as a singer.

MR: Okay.

TL: Yeah. Because that's where I began, and really I didn't become an instrumentalist until I was in my twenties.

MR: Did you do that out of necessity?

TL: Both necessity and desire. Necessity because I was on the road playing with some musicians that were truly terrible, and sometimes I would just tell them give me my first note or an introductory chord and sort of say lay out. Maybe the bass player knew the tune. And so the other reason was that I wanted to play with the best of musicians and I had to learn their language in order to keep up with them, and the dissatisfaction with the way that some people played, as opposed to the way that I wanted to hear it. And I heard my influences. The first one was McCoy Tyner and Chick Corea, and I had heard Bill Evans and so those were specifically the influences that catapulted me to try to play piano.

MR: What is a bad accompanist?

TL: Well either stylistically, if you're trying to do something that isn't in the style of the accompanist than they can take whatever you do and turn it into their style, instead of what you hope the style would be. And in essence I was very attracted to post-bop and modal. And then you would run into a purely bebop piano player who would not even

approach that idiom. Or a player who wouldn't approach ballads like maybe Bill Evans, or a beautiful player. They'd play bebop against the ballad. And I'd want to be getting romantic and hear bebop. And everything — as soon as you'd get done singing it doubles up and everybody starts swinging, and you know, there goes the romance. So I was hoping to keep things in its genre a little longer. And some of those players never did want to do that.

MR: I think being a singer can be a difficult proposition if you don't have — if you're not playing. Because just as you describe, like all of a sudden the trio pretty much just takes it out of your hands.

TL: Yes.

MR: So what are you going to do on stage?

TL: Right.

MR: Say, "No, I don't want double time here." It's too late.

TL: Exactly. That's right. So that's exactly why I started playing and then later I began playing a secondary keyboard when I could afford another piano player. I was my own mediocrity for a few years, playing very badly. But I was able to maybe not play so much but my hands are big and I can play maybe one beautiful, big change in a chord —in a bar — instead of two or three chords in the bar. And so I tried to follow Ellington's "edit yourself," and the old "less is more," and just encapsulate what I wanted to say in one change instead of trying to develop a facility — starting it in my twenties, it probably wasn't going to happen anyway.

MR: Well I think the thing you said about being able to speak the language is really important.

TL: It is.

MR: I've worked with a lot of singers who can't do that and it really makes it harder.

TL: It does. It limits everyone on the bandstand. So if the singer knows the realm of the musician then there can be a dialogue and the sky's the limit. But with limitations, you know, I tell the singers all the time that they have to know what they're singing and they have to be the time. That's a big thing with me. I think that singers rely on the band for the time and they float and they go behind or way behind. I think that the singer has an obligation to be the time, to evoke the time, either whether it's a ballad or an uptempo thing, whatever it is, so say that they can handle the time. They know where it is, and they can create the synergy that everyone playing the time can create.

MR: In your opinion, who is a good example of that?

TL: Wow. There was a lot, but I mean my first influences were Mel Torme, Sinatra, Ella, Sarah Vaughan, Carmen McRae, Billy Eckstine, even Vic Damone, Jack Jones, Joe Williams. So those people, whether specific tunes or in general, they either swung or were romantic and were able to carry these emotions – whatever they were singing —

they were able to convey that emotion. And I think a lot of it is in the time, as much as in the phrasing and the notation, you know?

MR: Did you have a musical household when you grew up?

TL: No, but my mother, getting up for breakfast in the morning, there was a great disc jockey in Cleveland, Ohio, where I was born, his name was Bill Randall, and he played all those great singers. And my mother, who came from a kind of blue collar, no frills background, but when the radio is on and a great singer was playing, she would just light up and start dancing around the kitchen and sing harmony with Mel Torme and Ella Fitzgerald. And she would break into harmony, and I would go, "How do you do that?" like cocking my head like some dog going "what?" And so I'm sure that she was definitely my musical influence. And it made her happy. And in the middle of sort of you know that blue collar kind of grimness, I wanted to make her happy too. So I think I started singing at five years old.

MR: Did you go through the high school chorus and all of that?

TL: I sang in the choir but I started singing professionally at 15 in a rock & roll band and did like the talent shows, and I was in choirs and things like that.

MR: Okay, when you were 15, what was rock & roll?

TL: Rock & roll was like Chuck Berry and then the Motown thing came in and then I left rock & roll when the British Invasion was coming in and the Four Seasons and all that, because everyone starting singing like a castrati. Everyone sang so high. And I was getting bigger and more baritone with every passing day. And I just realized that rock & roll had gone into some stratosphere that I'd have to sing falsetto. So that's when I sort of made the switch.

MR: Well walking over here you were talking about working at a young age, in Syracuse actually.

TL: Yes.

MR: And I'm curious, when you were doing that work and then you said you had a child at that time—

TL: Yeah.

MR: Was there some feeling like this is a hard thing I've chosen to do and now I have a family and I'm trying to be a professional singer. Was it a hard road?

TL: Well not quite then because I hadn't been, you know the baby was just coming like and I was at this club, the fifth largest club in the country, the Three Rivers Inn in Syracuse, so I was elated to be there. And playing, at 20, 21 years old, playing with a 15-piece house band every night with some great players from upstate, here. So I was actually in heaven and just wide-eyed and coming out of rock & roll, and I had done a little bit of more night club kind of things before I got to Syracuse, but this was my graduate course in music, it

really was, to see Ray Charles for nine days, and to see these great acts come in and just wide-eyed.

MR: What did you learn from watching those people?

TL: Well that's when I learned I'd probably have to play piano, because I saw Ray Charles come in and Buddy Greco came in and he said that he was making $1500 a week back in the forties with a hit record, and he gave it up to play piano with Benny Goodman for $150 a week. And he told me — he would take me out playing golf when people would invite him to the country club, so I'd go out and play golf with him. And he said, "What are you doing here? Why aren't you back singing somewhere?" He didn't want me being a house singer, an emcee, just having a little spot. So he said, "Go work, go out on the road, or go home and work a lot." And I think those examples: Ray Charles and Buddy Greco, kind of pointed me the way to piano. Because I saw that they were great musicians. They could sit down and play — well obviously Ray — but Buddy Greco too was a fine piano player. So with that example I think they kind of got my head on a little straight that I was going to have to become a musician.

MR: What about interacting with the audience. Did that come naturally for you, sort of — that's a big part of being a singer and being able to be sort of a front man.

TL: Yeah. Well I did it in rock & roll from 15 to about 20, and then when I got in the night club there, well I do remember the first time I was on this big stage and 1200 people out there in a theater restaurant, and I starting singing, my leg was going [trembling] like this, and my entire voice was quivering. So it took a little transition you know, and a little getting used to. But I think I was always fairly confident about the way I sang so if I knew the material, and you get past the initial nervousness and then it was okay.

MR: And you would be singing cover material, right?

TL: Absolutely. Standards, yeah, and cover material. And as I was saying Cal Custer, he was the assistant conductor of the Syracuse Symphony, arranged some things for me. So I had some specific material that I would do, and it was great.

MR: I thought about that arranging issue when I was listening to your recording with The Metropole Orchestra, and how fantastic those arrangements are. But I wonder if you've ever had a circumstance where you had arrangements written for you that didn't work and what do you do?

TL: You know I can't say that I have because actually I haven't had that many arrangements. Cal wrote some then, when I was very young, and these arrangements, but I was never in a position to play with that large an ensemble usually. That big band in Syracuse, and the Orchestra were the exceptions.

MR: Okay.

TL: So I would — mostly small groups.

MR: I'd have to put down, amongst your things, that you seem to be an arranger to me also though.

TL: I do think in those terms.

MR: Yeah. Because some of the tunes, you're a song-put-together person.

TL: Yes.

MR: You know, on some of your CDs, what's the one you did —

TL: "Baubles, Bangles" and "I Get a Kick Out of You."

MR: And "Ain't No Mountain High Enough?"

TL: "Ain't No Mountain High Enough" and "Still Haven't Found What I'm Lookin'For" from U2.

MR: Right.

TL: Yeah, you know I talk to Kenny Werner, a great piano player, and he would always quote other tunes in the middle of his solos, you know, a lot of players do that.

MR: Yeah.

TL: And I think that came with experience. You just hear progressions and chords and how things are similar and then all of a sudden you just kind of assimilate this ability to hear these things and — oh that sounds like — and then, but that was a late development, very.

MR: Yeah. Do you have songwriting tools that you use at home to write? I mean do you do things on tape and then listen back or do computer —

TL: Well I have the computer but I usually do that post-writing. No I just kind of sit there and play piano until I get a series, a progression or a series of changes that intrigues me. Usually the changes come first and then I'll write the melody and the lyrics.

MR: Okay, that was the proverbial question, which comes first?

TL: Yeah, usually the changes, the chords. And I'll set that up and if that's intriguing to me then I'll work on a melody that is hopefully as intriguing, and then I'll try to write some lyrics that don't embarrass me. Because that's a big deal with me too.

MR: Do your songs seem to naturally fall into some kind of standard form? Like when you're writing you say, okay it's time, I need a bridge here. Or are they just more —

TL: Organic, huh?

MR: Organic or —

TL: You know that's a good question. I can't honestly give you an answer because I think if there's a criticism of me it may be that I'm a little too eclectic. Or as George Bush says "echolectic." Anyway — that's whole 'nother subject. So this eclecticism, I search for the not standard. You know I try to write things that maybe aren't in the proverbial forms, or A-A-B-A. I search for those things that are slightly different that maybe I can put my imprint on that may be a little more individual. And sometimes that works, and

sometimes I fall back into the A-A-B kind of thing. But usually I'm looking for something that intrigues my sensibilities and then I feel that all music has to come through me to get to you. If it doesn't intrigue me it's going to come out at about three inches and fall to the floor. If I feel it, then there's a good chance of me conveying that to you. So that's how I feel about composition too, and melody and lyrics.

MR: Have you ever written either a song or an arrangement — I'm trying to think how to phrase this — in response to something that's popular at the time, and you think like that's the direction I need to go here.

TL: I don't know about popular, but again, intriguing. It might be, I remember writing a couple of tunes that had sort of a "Birdland" kind of rhythm because I was intrigued by that rhythm. But not to — you know I have a theory about populism, and that is that if you chase that populism train you'll never catch it. And if you did the trend will have been over. So I figured I don't know exactly when it was, maybe in my late twenties, I said that I was going to set out on my own path and hope to intersect a trend, because I was never going to catch one. And I felt that way about it.

MR: That's the nature of trends, you have to start them I think.

TL: Yeah. Or as they say, intersect it. And maybe you never will. I mean that possibility exists and I dealt with that too. So at this point, a little more philosophically, I'm just looking to create a body of work and hopefully it will stand the test of time, and I may not be around for that time, but when you look back, the great composers and the people that have influenced all of us, you know I don't think they were writing for their specific time. They were writing what they felt and what it meant to them, and it lived because it was timeless. So that's what I aspire to. Whether you achieve that, time will tell.

MR: Was your mother happy that you became a professional musician?

TL: I think so. I think that she was worried, you know, and my father always said, "Well why don't you just like be a barber or something, have a trade." And he was probably right, because it with the oscilloscope pattern of the ups and downs of music, I probably should have had a trade or something. But I've been very fortunate that there's that philosophy of cornucopia, you get not everything you want but you get just enough to proceed, and I've been very fortunate in that regard.

MR: That's a good observation. I'm curious if you — how much of your musical knowledge and so forth came from the educational system?

TL: Well none as a singer. I never studied — I had a quasi-manager when I was singing rock & roll who brought some teachers in from the Cleveland Institute and they said don't mess with him, just maybe he needs some breathing or something, but stylistically leave him alone. Because the teacher will teach him to sing the way they do. But then when I went to piano I studied with Bill Dobbins, who I was working with, he had the Kent State

lab band in Kent State, but I was fortunate to work with him, and I studied with him and Bill Gidney, a great jazz pianist who is in Cleveland, and Phil Rizzo, who used to arrange for the Stan Kenton band. I studied theory from Phil, and then went to Bill Dobbins and Bill gave me transcriptions of all the pianists, you know Chick Corea and Monk and, you know, so I was able to use those transcriptions to see their styles and assimilate some of that. So I did study theory and some piano.

MR: Okay. Do you have a feeling about jazz education these days?

TL: Well having taught in the schools, some schools in the U.S., and I taught for a semester as a guest professor in Graz, Austria, at KUG there, which, it's a very prestigious, one of the only jazz schools, maybe the only one in Austria. And I prefer the European. Because it seems to me that the educational system in the U.S. stops at — like Ken Burns' jazz documentary, it stops at 1955 or wherever. They don't even go into the sixties and beyond. So maybe that's changed now or it maybe in other programs, but the programs that I taught in, I thought they were a little bit anachronistic, frankly.

MR: Are you talking about like jazz schools?

TL: Yes.

MR: Gee that's interesting you say that, because some people feel that the jazz, a lot of the current jazz teachers or players start at Coltrane.

TL: Well I don't see them teaching that though. I see them teaching bebop, much more.

MR: Oh, right. Yes.

TL: Much more than Coltrane or Joe Henderson, or that kind of, yeah. I see it, you know, pre-that.

MR: And how would you teach Coltrane?

TL: Well that's a good question. I wouldn't, frankly, because I don't think I'm qualified. But no, as a singer, I try to give them a spectrum that takes them into the modern post-bop modal kind of thing because that's what intrigued me. I don't think I would have been a jazz musician had I been limited to bebop. Bebop — I don't think it's a great singer's music. I think, and in fact, I feel that when — I wrote a whole article on my web site about jazz dividing and conquering itself.

MR: I want to talk about that.

TL: Yeah. Well that's a big thing to me. Because I think the bebop era took the singers out of the music. All the great singers — Ella and Sarah and Billy Eckstine, all those great singers were in the swing era. And then when bebop came in it got very analytical, very — it's a brilliant music, and difficult, but as an idiom for singers I don't think it was wonderful because there were these perfunctory little heads that went on to the long solos. And those perfunctory little heads were nothing for the singer to sing. And I think it gave rise to a lot of singers who weren't the best of the crop, that sang those

perfunctory little heads, and then did all the vocalese or scatting as the bebop players did, where I was looking for the content in the lyric and the emotion of the songs that was generated in the swing era. So then I totally — as my taste I should say — totally skipped the bebop era, I think I came in with "Milestones." I heard "Milestones" and went wow.

MR: Isn't that a great record?

TL: Right. And then, 'cause it skipped those bar lines and started floating over the bar lines, you know, that [scats] that I just went wow, what is that? And then I heard McCoy and doing his modal thing and that was another thing that just slayed me. I just said wow, this is, that's what made me play piano. Two specific compositions: McCoy Tyner's "Man From Tanganyika" which I performed last night, and Chick Corea's "Tones for Joan's Bones." I heard them and I just was floored. I said, so I wanted to play with them and unfortunately they were booked, so I had to, that's when I started playing piano.

MR: Did you hear them live?

TL: I have, both of them, yeah. There was a great club in Cleveland that we would open for many acts, and I got to open for Bill Evans where I met Eddie Gomez and subsequently recorded with him later, and Jimmy Smith and so they all came through, and six nights, and we got to hear them. So everybody came through: Miles and McCoy and Keith Jarrett and the first version of Weather Report.

MR: Wow.

TL: So this was a very enlightening time for me.

MR: What's the first tune, instrumental tune, that you were inspired to —

TL: [Scats].

MR: Really?

TL: Yes. I was about seven, eight. I started singing that solo.

MR: That's a great solo. That is — it's so funny you say that, because that's like the perfect solo.

TL: I just loved it. I just couldn't get enough of it.

MR: That was Bobby Hackett, wasn't it?

TL: I thought it was Wardell Gray. Maybe it was Bobby Hackett.

MR: I think it's Bobby Hackett.

TL: Yeah, you probably know better than I. But it was "String of Pearls," and it was just, I loved it as a kid. That was definitely —

MR: There's a funny anecdote that Joe Wilder told me about that. They were playing "In the Mood" at some T.V. thing or something, and the trumpet player said, "Watch this." And he played that solo over "In the Mood" right?

TL: I believe it.

MR: The conductor's going, "What?"

TL: A man after my own heart. I love that kind of thing. Yeah that was it. I just was so — it was rapturous. It's beautiful.

MR: And what lyric did you — did you write a lyric to that?

TL: No.

MR: Okay.

TL: In fact, I have never written a lyric to a solo.

MR: Okay. Right. That's more like the vocalese.

TL: That's the vocalese, yeah. No I just write them to the heads of tunes.

MR: What, I'm sometimes curious as to what makes you pick a particular song.

TL: It's just those things and intrigue me, yeah, that either they sink into my head and I can't get them out of my head, or they're so just intriguing, either the changes or the intervals or whatever in the melody, like McCoy's "Man from Tanganyika" was in twelve-eight and it had these bars of nine-eight. And I didn't even know that until later, but it was just so staccato and so flowing over the twelve-eight. And the twelve-eight was so exotic.

MR: I was impressed by the words that you managed to articulate on that last night.

TL: Thanks.

MR: And I'm wondering if the story, you hear that melody, do you come up sort of with a theme or a story line and then try to fashion the words to get the story to go with the melody?

TL: I literally went to the library and looked up Tanganyika and started studying about Tanganyika to find some material. And then I wanted to evoke the dignified primitive nature of things; how these people may be primitive but they existed long before governments, and that intrigued me. And McCoy said he wrote it about a man he met from Tanganyika. So that was all that I knew about it from the album that it came on. So I just tried to — and I really wanted to pay homage to the influences of African — the African influence that it had on me because I was very intrigued by it. And this is an African based music, you know, and it comes from there and I'm, you know I wanted to pay some respect to that and be respectful of it and so I included as much respect as I could in the tribal sense and then tried to convey that, you know, generations pass and as the generations passed it turned from Tanganyika into Tanzania and that occurred and these people probably had no idea and they just proceeded in their own culture and kept it. And to me there's a definite dignity there that I wanted convey. And it's profound. There was a profoundness that I heard in "Man from Tanganyika." It was like African classical music to me.

MR: What got you into Brazilian music?

TL: Well I was aware of, in the sixties I was aware of Stan Getz and Astrud Gilberto and Joao Gilberto and that era of things. But some musicians in Cleveland, Skip Hadden, who now

teaches at Berklee, drums at Berklee, he was very broad and he would bring records by Hermeto Pascoal and when I heard Milton Nascimento and people like that, in the early seventies. And then the second tune I ever wrote lyrics to was Keith Jarrett's "Lucky Southern" with Airto Moreira was on it, an Airto album. And it was a samba, and there's another rhythm. The exotic rhythms — I love Brazilian music because, like jazz, it has influences from Africa, they had slavery there and imported a lot of Africans. So there was the same elements that created jazz in our country, in America, were present in Brazil with different, slightly different influences — the Indian influence there was different so they brought the jungle sounds in, but the African influence was very heavy, and the European/ Portuguese influence. So we had European influences and the African mix to make jazz. And down there those influences mixed to make Brazilian music. So to me there's a logic there that those same elements came together to intrigue me again. And I'm Italian. So my Latin thing comes out there. I don't like, necessarily, Italian music, but it certainly comes out in the Brazilian.

MR: How so?

TL: Well you know I mean the Italian thing is very operatic or very hyper-romantic, but the Brazilian thing I think, in jazz, there's this hard edge thing where, you know, I think that there was elements where people thought I was gay because I wanted to be romantic in jazz. Whereas in Brazilian music you can be macho and you can be romantic in Mexican or Spanish music or Cuban music or Brazilian music you can be very macho and still be very hyper-romantic. Whereas in jazz there's always this hard edge Trane, kind of hard, big, brassy, don't get — I like the romantic. I like to appeal to the other half of the audience. And so that comes out in Brazilian music without any trouble.

MR: I see.

TL: That's really it.

MR: Have you had a chance to go there?

TL: I have. Yes. And I've — Toninho Horta who is a collaborator of mine, is in New York now, we've just been talking, so I may go down there to record with him. But I have been to Brazil and the people walk with rhythm. It's a beautiful thing.

MR: I had an experience once when I was in school, at a public school, and I played the beginning of the Paul Simon record —

TL: Yeah. With Milton or —

MR: It was just those snare drums going. And there was a Brazilian exchange student in the class and he perked up immediately and I said oh this is real then.

TL: That's right.

MR: Very interesting. A signature sound.

TL: It's a very earth-connected music to me, because of all those influences. They have jungle sounds and the cuica and all these instruments that evoke the jungle and then you have those beautiful harmonies from Europe, and then you have this more primitive — primitive is hardly the word because it's very sophisticated. The rhythms are very sophisticated. Baion and samba and the way they dance, I mean, and seven-four sambas and my God, those are very sophisticated. So all these elements, you know there is this element of primitiveness but the culmination is very sophisticated to me.

MR: Yeah it's interesting what we call primitive.

TL: Yeah it really is.

MR: But I liked your explanation of thinking of seven-four as two sections that becomes fourteen.

TL: Yeah. Well you know a drummer explained that to me, and I went — oh the dawn, you know. It was like —

MR: Are you influenced at all by nature in your writing in your inspirations?

TL: Yes. Yeah. Because the more society gets away from nature and diminishes the integral part that it plays in our life, the more I want to go back to it, yes. Very much. I love to write about the wind and the water and, you know, the Emerald Forests and things. I do. I love to bring nature into it. Because that's the more realism. That's where the realism is. You know you can easily give emotion to those things.

MR: Were you influenced — you have two daughters?

TL: I have two daughters and a son.

MR: Have you been influenced at all over the years by the music they listened to as they grew up?

TL: Oh yes. They've opened me up to some — I must say my older daughter and my son too, has influenced me. My younger daughter not so much. But now I've influenced her. She has a compilation of Brazilian music and some of it is very earthy Brazilian music that she now likes. But yeah, to some extent.

MR: You mentioned — I think you called it the "oscilloscope of a career."

TL: Yes.

MR: And sort of tying in with your thing you wrote about jazz recordings. Has there been a time, a series of years, that were the best and a series of years that were really the hardest for you?

TL: Working — absolutely. And that has been, you now I have found, frankly, that the more individualistic I get, the less I work. When you don't cover and follow those trends then you become an entity that has no bearing on anything that's currently happening. So it moves you out of the mainstream somewhat. Yet I view those times as maybe some of my most productive times because I learned to play piano and about nine years ago

started playing nylon string guitar for the Brazilian things, from the influence of Toninho Horta, my favorite Brazilian composer and guitarist. And so those down periods had their own benefits, even though they were not necessarily great financial years. But I can't say that I'm happy with the amount that I have been able to actually sing. You know I would have liked to have been performing much more than my career has afforded me.

MR: What has to happen these days, to get three nights in a row at the Blue Note for instance?

TL: Well, you know, if I knew that maybe I could get three nights. I frankly don't know. My business acumen is not anything to write home about. But again, I think I've taken a longer philosophical view that I'm going to try to create a body of work and, as I said, cornucopia has allowed me to do that, maybe not on the highest level of economic plateaus, but I don't know. I think that the current musical scene is quite detrimental to quality. There is — I hear singers that just are abysmal in many genres, and I quote Ray Charles about rap, he says "it's just talkin'."

MR: It's just talkin'. Yeah.

TL: And so I just quote Ray. Because it is. It's literally just talkin'. So that has been very detrimental. I think people, there are so many anti-Christs that I have, you know, of singers that I don't think belong in front of a microphone that are very popular now. They have, they sound like frogs croaking a song out and they have no pitch and I mean it goes from Bruce Springsteen to Elvis Costello and I think these people are frauds. Just utter total frauds.

MR: Do you think the American Idol syndrome and stuff plays into that?

TL: Well that's like — well I'll tell you a bigger overview is that I think that business has conspired to bring the masses into music. They want the masses to — you know they want you to be a singer. They want everyone to be able to sing. So now instead of to get to Carnegie Hall you practice, practice, practice, now you, like they promoted the pet rock, you just promote something until it's so popular you can buy Carnegie Hall. And that's how I feel about it. I feel that the quality that the great musicians that you've interviewed and that we all know have spent these years trying to hone a craft and all of a sudden that quality doesn't matter. It's not about that anymore. It's about something else. And that something else is a scandalous scheme, a businessman's dream — that's a lyric that's coming.

MR: Okay.

TL: And that's what it is. I feel that all these Harvard graduates, business graduates, they're going well why do I want to deal with a temperamental artist. Let me create Milli Vanilli. And so I blame, you know, in a culture the tallest things in that culture are the most important things. And it used to be churches and now it's Citi Corps.

MR: Now it's what?

TL: City Corps, you know, or you know what I mean? Corporate buildings. So they have that bottom line. And that bottom line and art, they don't mix, they shouldn't mix.

MR: Some fellows that I talked to, had pointed out that years ago the heads of the record companies were musicians.

TL: Yes.

MR: And that they felt it made a big difference.

TL: Well it does. That's what I'm saying. These business, Harvard business graduates, they learn to sell anything. So why do they want to deal with temperamental quality? Or maybe not even temperamental, they don't know. They were trained in business. They weren't trained in music. So maybe they like, maybe they think the sun sets with Bruce Springsteen.

MR: What's your — I played a gig a couple of months ago and some woman said to me, "We want to hear those older songs, those Rod Stewart songs."

TL: Right. There's another one. I didn't mention him, should have.

MR: I said Rod Stewart songs, then I finally figured out what she was talking about, you know.

TL: Oh the standards album that he recorded.

MR: Yeah. Rod doing the standards.

TL: Right. You know I say well let me say, let me drink booze for about twenty years and have a little sip of hydrochloric acid and then I'll go into the studio. That's what it would take for me to get to that place. And I just reject it totally.

MR: I see. Well if you could get in a time machine, is there a couple of moments — well not necessarily just jazz history — but maybe where would you like to go back to, to be a fly on the wall?

TL: Yeah you know I guess I don't think in terms like that. I think that hopefully one views their career as an ascent, you know, so for me going back, you mean historically?

MR: I just mean like is there a record date or something that you'd like to have watched or something like that?

TL: Well maybe Sinatra and Nelson Riddle or something like that era where there was a great arranger and a full orchestra and I could just not worry about anything but singing the song. You know, maybe that era, right.

MR: Yeah. That must have been a heck of a feeling when you did that with the Metropole Orchestra. Did you do that live?

TL: We did it live. Yeah. And John Clayton conducted. So it was the thrill of my life. It came out of the blue. Mark Murphy had told me to send my material to the Netherlands. And then I did, I sent the material and I got an email maybe eight months, nine months later, maybe a year. And the producer said that he just kept listening to my record. He just kept

playing it and he goes back to it. And he said, "I can't promise you anything but I'm keeping you in mind." And then I did a performance at the IAJE in New York in 1998 with Joe Locke and Tony Marino, who was just on the gig last night, and Jamey Haddad. And he was there and we signed a contract to do it the next day, for a year and a month later. I had to wait 13 months to do it, and it was the longest period. That was such a thrill. I had to keep my welled up tears down in the middle of a couple of those takes just 'cause I was just — I did, out of the studio I did shed a few tears just of happiness. It was, my wife was there, it was a totally elating time, it was a thrill.

MR: How much input did you have with your arrangers?

TL: I spoke to Mike Abene and Vince Mendoza and Chuck Owen. But I didn't speak to the Dutch arranger that arranged two tunes on that, and I was sorry, and I think the producer was kind of sorry. I think he didn't want me to actually communicate with them too much. He wanted, you know, some individuality there and that we'd all come together. But I spoke and talked at length with three of the arrangers out of the four.

MR: You gave them your keys and here's my idea of —

TL: Well conceptually, yeah. And then I know Mike Abene wrote in some extensions in the tunes and you'd get to the rehearsal and you'd find out then, the first day, what these charts sound like. You never hear them. So I got there on a Monday, I heard them rehearsing the charts Monday, we started rehearsing on Tuesday, and we were supposed to finish rehearsing on Wednesday and then record Thursday and Friday. No I'm sorry, we were supposed to rehearse one day and then begin recording on the second day. And we didn't get through the rehearsals. The charts were tough and very involved. So we started recording late on Wednesday and we had Wednesday and Thursday and then we did fixes, the orchestra fixes and I had a couple on Friday and we were out of there. What a thrill though. It was just a great thrill. It's something I never — you know it was a dream come true because there's that Nelson Riddle Orchestra thing, and it was a total dream before that. And I'll never forget that.

MR: Kind of interesting that it happened across the pond as they say.

TL: Yeah it really was, ironic.

MR: Do you get to travel around much overseas?

TL: Yeah I've traveled in Europe. I haven't really been to Asia yet but South America and Europe.

MR: Did I see some photos of you in Australia?

TL: Yeah. I was in — that's true, I forgot about that. Australia and New Zealand last fall. That was a great experience too.

MR: Reception different?

TL: You know the road is wonderful. Everywhere I go on the road, I wish New York was like that, you know. No, I was totally in love with European audiences and Australia and New Zealand were wonderful, South America was wonderful, yeah.

MR: Well I promised I would play a couple of things for you. Let me see if I can make this happen here.

[audio interlude]

TL: Got to be Nancy [Wilson], right?

MR: Yeah. I'm just curious if you recall this particular record as a singer. It's not the ones I was looking for. Here's one I was looking for.

TL: "Happy Talk." Sure. She's killing, Nancy. And "Never Will I Marry" oh my, my. No, Nancy's beautiful. You know I studied all this. I didn't mention Nancy and I should have. I studied as many of the good singers as I could, I mean laying down on the floor in front of the speakers just studying them. And I went through all of them and the last one was Carmen McRae, who I'm born on Carmen's birthday and I didn't even know that, and I just loved the way she could go from soft and tender to hard and edgy and nasty almost. And she is a great interpreter. And then I stopped, at about 24, when I started playing piano, I stopped listening to singers for influence. I went to the instrumentalists. And I think it's, with all the influence that I got from these wonderful singers, then I went to the instrumentalists who were playing all these different linear approaches. And that's how I hoped I would develop into something slightly different than my predecessors. And I don't know if I have or not but I know that the study of music has helped me to go to places that some, I feel a lot of singers, haven't gone, at least on that path. But she is so good.

MR: I love the record too. She's got these cool arrangements with Cannonball and Nat.

TL: Oh yeah. I saw them live in Cleveland when I was 18 years old and there was a great club called Leo's Casino, and you had to put leis around your neck because you couldn't drink at 18, and you had these Hawaiian leis on your neck and my future wife and I were sitting there, and we saw Cannonball and Nancy and loved every minute of it.

MR: Oh you saw the two of them together.

TL: Yes.

MR: Oh, I'm jealous.

TL: Oh it was sizzling. I loved it.

MR: He's my favorite.

TL: Me too. I quote him in a lyric, Cannonball.

MR: Do you?

TL: I do, in "Keeper of the Flame."

MR: What was it that grabbed you about him?

TL: Well you know everybody loves Charlie Parker you know. And I love Charlie too, but I think Cannonball did more with less. He swung harder with less. Do you feel that way?

MR: I think, plus his tone was, I mean as a saxophone player it's like well there you go.

TL: There you go. And he used the Latin thing and he expanded, he was a big influence as far as my Latin thing, you know. There was a great tune by Victor Feldman, "Azule Serape." Oh, what a great tune, knocked me down, loved it.

MR: Wow. Yup. Well here's a — I don't think I've ever asked this question of anybody but I'll try it out on you. Do you believe in any kind of reincarnation?

TL: Yes. I do. I think that there is a spirit, because I don't know if we come back as the same type of being, or even on this planet you know. But I do think that when we leave something, some echo of us, maybe it goes to another dimension literally, but you know I have no idea where it goes and I'm not — I have no philosophy about that. But I don't think it ends.

MR: Okay. Because I'm often curious about, well in your case, why does someone born in Cleveland, right, become attracted to the African influence or Brazilian music or where do these things come from? Why are you opened up to those kinds of opportunities?

TL: You know I can trace that back to one phrase when I was studying for my first holy communion and some witch-like nun said, "You know if you're not Catholic you're going to hell." And I thought, oh my God, all the people preceding Jesus Christ, all the — they're all in hell? And I rejected it right there. And so any — I reject tribalism of any kind. And I think that countries and religions and races and nationalities, those are all tribes. And if we can leave the tribal then we can ascend as a whole. So that's why I don't feel superior or inferior to anyone, but I certainly don't feel superior to anyone. And if you feel that way then everyone has validity, you know? Everyone. Somebody cleaning the street or the president — well I don't want to go there.

MR: Well I wanted to go there.

TL: Yeah. Go right ahead.

MR: Your Bush league. You're talking about your Bush league. I'm making an educated guess that you're not too happy with the current state of affairs.

TL: Yeah I think it's the greatest travesty this country has endured. I thought Nixon was bad, I thought Reagan split up the — in fact I thought Reagan began the entire whole rap movement and all that when he said, I don't think he was necessarily racist I just think that he said if you don't have money I'm sorry, I can't deal with you. And so that took a lot of people and just put them out of society's flow. And then this guy came along, and he has rewritten all the rules or broken all the rules I think. He is a travesty. I think he is the most detrimental thing this country has endured. Period. I think the election in 2000, I was on the streets the day after the election. I had a sign that said "Supreme C-O-U-R-T"

and the bottom said "C-O-U de etat. Because that's what I think we've endured. I think the Supreme Court vote that took one vote to change the national election — you know I just read in the *Times* that it's within the Constitution with a majority of Congress they can change the number of Supreme Court justices and it's been down to five and as high as eleven.

MR: Really?

TL: Yes.

MR: I didn't know that.

TL: I didn't know that either. I read it in the *Times* about three days ago. I was amazed. So that decision and placing this figurehead in office against the popular vote, I just think it's a travesty. I do everything I can, I write letters, I write funny things, or try to.

MR: "Dick Cheney sings Cheney of Fools."

TL: Right. My favorite is Condoleeza Rice sings "Oh What a Beautiful Warning."

MR: "Oh What a Beautiful Warning."

TL: Right.

MR: You almost have to make some fun.

TL: Well you do. You literally have to make light of it because that's how devastating it is I feel.

MR: Do you think we can repair it? How? How can we repair it?

TL: I think for the benefit of the country, this man above all, needs to be impeached. I wrote an article that was actually printed — or a letter that was printed in the *Long Island,* (New York) *Newsday* and it was about crying wolf. The impeachment of Clinton was a terrible thing. It shouldn't have happened for an affair between two people. No one other than them. But the result of that was that everyone is now afraid to impeach the actual wolf. Because this guy is the wolf and he's in the White House. And now everyone's afraid to go through that process. But constitutionally he's been abysmal. There are now right wing Heritage Foundation people and left wingers that are now getting together and saying that he needs to be impeached. And there was just a brilliant Bill Moyers *Journal* two weeks ago that these two opposites were on the air with Bill Moyers saying that for the benefit of this country we need to impeach this man. Because it's not going to go away. And to leave this precedence is the most detrimental thing to our country that I have witnessed in my lifetime.

MR: Including the late sixties when everything was in such turmoil?

TL: Well at least the late sixties the population rose. They rose up and said enough of this. Enough. Sixty-five thousand deaths. Well we aren't up to that high but this, you don't know what this man can do in eighteen months, that's where we are at this point. And I frankly fear. I fear that under this administration we have crested that hill and we are now

on the downward slope as the Roman Empire was. I actually feel that. I'm no expert, this is just my feeling and opinion.

MR: Well and hope for better days is in your song.

TL: This is exactly what I wrote it for. I was in Europe. I went to Europe at the end of September in 2001, and I got there and my colleagues were saying, "Is CNN part of government?"

MR: "Is CNN part of government?"

TL: Part of the U.S. — they were asking because they had taken up the line of the Bush administration about, you know, we have to go to war. They had hook, line and sinker become part of his thrust. And they were wondering what's going on. How come the BBC is the only thing that they were getting good information from. Yeah. And one other thing, when you said going to Europe to record that album with the orchestra. You know I came back from Europe and people would say, "Well how was it." I said, "Well in the United States I'm a degenerate jazz musician. There, I have colleagues."

MR: Really.

TL: And that's how it felt. It was wonderful there. I had a classical teacher teaching under my chair. It was unbelievable. So that's another difference that I would like to point out.

MR: Did you tell me, again, where you were teaching?

TL: I was teaching at KUG Graz.

MR: KUG okay.

TL: Kunst University Graz in Graz, Austria.

MR: Wow. How did you get a gig like that?

TL: Mark Murphy again. Mark Murphy has been a wonderful friend and I love the way he sings and I'm happy to say he likes the way I sing. So actually Nancy King, a great singer from Portland, Oregon was supposed to do it and she broke her leg. So it's like, "Break a leg, Nancy." Literally.

MR: It's okay.

TL: And so I got the gig.

MR: What do you say to aspiring jazz musicians these days?

TL: Musicians or singers?

MR: Well don't you want a singer to be a musician?

TL: Well that's what I tell them.

MR: Okay.

TL: That's why I'm delineating. Because there are two things. I don't have that much influence or run across that many jazz musicians that I can influence. So the singers are the ones that I run into. And I tell them that they will never reach the place that they aspire to unless (a) they become a musician; (b) they are the time, the rhythm. They have

to be the time. They cannot rely on the musicians to take them through the time. They have to reflect it.

MR: That's great advice. Do you have specific —

TL: Methodologies? Yeah. I make 'em play shaker.

MR: All right.

TL: I take out, I get a little egg, a two dollar egg, that's the first thing I say, let's go buy an egg and then you go play with the radio and rock & roll and funk and R&B and jazz and Latin music and anything you can, obviously straight ahead four-four it's not the greatest thing, but it doesn't matter. If they go to the other idioms and get, just, and I tell them you know it's hard until it's not. And that might be a day, it might be a month. But it's hard to do until it's not and then you lock it in and it becomes that heartbeat and you internalize it and all of a sudden you can conduct with that little egg.

MR: That is great advice.

TL: Thank you.

MR: I'm going to steal that for sure.

TL: Please do.

MR: I've got instrumentalists who could profit from that. I just never really thought of that, that it's obviously that they're not really internalizing.

TL: Right. I tell them to become part of the rhythm section that way. And when the drummer is playing a solo or if it's a Latin, a bossa nova, and I tell them, you know, you can conduct. If you're playing a boss nova and you're going, and you go, it's all of a sudden it's a samba. You can double it up and you can conduct the band that you're playing with. And it's an integral part of you immersing yourself into the band and the band knows it. If you have time, the band is going to respect you. It's not going to be like oh we've got to play for the singer. And you know there's that.

MR: There is.

TL: And we were talking about that, you know you broached that earlier, that there is a definite separation. And some musicians don't like you because you sing the head. Some musicians don't like you because they don't think you're as talented as they are musically because you're not a musician. So the burden of a singer is to get through those elements that are holding you down. You have to prove to them that you belong there, number one, and the best way to do that, I have found, is with time and to become — at least know the changes, you know, know the changes. I've been on bandstands and I call a tune and the bass player doesn't know the tune and I'm feeding him the changes and they're going, "Really?" They don't believe it. And all of a sudden you have the respect and they play for you so much better.

MR: That's right. The fellow Rick Montalbano I mentioned, told me a singer joke, it was real though. You know. Someone wanted to sing a tune with him and he said — I have to get this right — he said, "That's a little high can you do it in minor?"

TL: Oh, no. Right.

MR: You know, that kind of thing.

TL: Yeah, yeah. I believe, that's right. Well that's the kind of stuff that, and you know I must come down on a lot of singers that rely on the musicians. There are a lot of singers there that they think they can get away with that. And I tell them all the time it's your fault, it's not their fault, it's the singer's fault. Your responsibility is to come up to the players, not the players to come down to you. That's not the ideal.

MR: Wow. Are they teaching that at the New School?

TL: I don't frankly know. I don't know. I hope so, but I'm not sure.

MR: No, it's good advice. And I did enjoy your performance last night and thought you had a good way with the audience.

TL: Thank you.

MR: And I think the musicians you work with appreciate the fact that — this is such a little thing — but when the gig is over like you're in there helping load the car and all that stuff.

TL: Oh sure.

MR: You know it's just like such a way to be.

TL: Yeah. I'm, that's what I mean, I don't think I'm superior to anyone or inferior, but certainly not superior. And I know those guys are so talented. And now I'm playing and I'm lugging around my own keyboard and guitar. So no, no airs, no airs.

MR: Yeah. I wonder if you ever said boy why did I learn piano, now I've got to buy something, I've got to buy a PA, I've got to like —

TL: Well I used to have to carry that around, as a singer you have to carry your own PA, but then it got much worse with heavy keyboards and Fender Rhodes —

MR: Oh God, did you own one of those?

TL: Oh I had a Fender Rhodes and I lived, when I first moved to New York I lived on the sixth floor of an elevator building and the elevator would break constantly and I would have to lug that thing up six floors. It was insane, yeah. And I remember a number of times I hit the landing and the thing went over, and it knocked all the screws out. It was so impacted, all the screws unscrewed and I had to go upstairs, get a screwdriver and put it back together before I put it in the car to go to the gig. Yeah. I've been there.

MR: I always, I take it for granted when I'm from here, playing a gig, and I can time it. I can leave my house 45 minutes before I'm supposed to be somewhere and play, because I know how long it's going to take me and I know the load in, but I always felt sorry for

people in Manhattan who had to play a gig and park their car somewhere and load in and then go re-park their car. That must be a little hard.

TL: Yeah. What we do for love.

MR: I guess so.

TL: Yeah. You learn to — I bought a little GK amplifier — we were talking — changed my life. I mean they made things smaller and more compact and you used to have to lug around big Fender Rhodes and big amps and it's gotten a little better.

MR: That is one good thing, the older we get the smaller our gear.

TL: Right. And thankfully.

MR: I just wanted to ask you, the song you wrote called I think "It Takes Two?"

TL: Uh "Taken to Heart?" No wait.

MR: It's off, I can't remember where I put my CDs now. It's about it only takes the number two.

TL: Oh "Count to Two."

MR: "Count to Two" thank you. I'm curious, those little turns of a phrase, where do they come from?

TL: You know I don't know. Trying not to — I don't want to use clichés as clichés, but I love to take clichés — I love double entendre. My second album was entitled "Double Entendre." So that's how much I love them. So I try to just put a little twist on things and maybe turn it around or juxtapose something, you know, like the tunes I like to juxtapose. So I don't know, and you know that tune specifically came from a comment that Eddie Gomez made. You know we were playing, he's such a great player and so technically proficient, and I said well let's play a samba. And I can't remember how it got — he said, "Oh anybody can play in two." It's like he said, "It's easy to play in two." And I thought at that time it wasn't easy for me to play in two. And so that's actually the basis of that tune. But lyrically that's what it is. I like to take things that maybe were clichés and take elements of them and mix them in with double entendres and turn 'em around.

MR: Yeah. Because I saw like almost two story lines in there, or it developed from one thing to the next.

TL: Right.

MR: I wonder if it takes — is that a long process for you?

TL: You know I think —

MR: The tweaking?

TL: Well I try, I do tweak some, but usually the lyrics come out — not entire intact — but relatively intact. And then they have long gestation periods before, between writing and recording. So I live with them for a while, and then they'll modify. On the other hand, I wrote the second verse for "Taken to Heart" with the orchestra on the plane to the

Netherlands. Because I only had one verse on the Concord album that I recorded it on and they wanted to redo it, and I said oh I've got to get a second verse, so I wrote it on the plane. So some things happen. I sat for three weeks with "Mountain Flight," couldn't write a thing and then one day I wrote them in three hours. So it's very varied. Very.

MR: Sometimes desperation leads to inspiration.

TL: Absolutely. I like time constraints. They seem to crystallize things. The pressure's on, okay, you know, maybe I can turn this rock, this piece of coal into a diamond, in that — it's Superman. So I don't know, but yeah. I just try — I aspire to write lyrics that I'm not embarrassed singing. That's really the bottom line. 'Cause I hear jazz specifically, you know, those bebop tunes and everything, I really have a problem with the lyrics in some jazz tunes.

MR: Well those things weren't —

TL: They're perfunctory.

MR: Yeah. And they weren't written with that in mind.

TL: Right. They wanted to get to the solo. Everything is to get to the solo.

MR: To get to the solo. I concur. What's coming up in the near future for you?

TL: Well I just got together with Toninho Horta just before I came up here and we're planning a duet album and we are putting that together right now. And then I have, again it's been a year since the last album came out so I've been compiling material. I have some sessions planned but not specifically dated. And I'm going to do the material that I've been accumulating. There's Maraca Valle, "Land of Maraca Valle," a Cuban flautist, I'm writing lyrics to his tune and I'm going to record that. Actually the lyrics are done. And another Toninho Horta composition that we're going to record both on the album with him and another album that I'm going to record. So I'm in the throes of trying to put together another album, and teaching privately. Gigs — you got any?

MR: They come and they go. I got one for you tonight.

TL: You provided this it was a lot of fun and I thank you, right on camera for that. Thank you very much.

MR: I'm glad to be able to do that. Does it help to have a record label these days?

TL: I don't know that it does. Because I was on Concord, I was on Inner City, I was on Adventure Music, and I didn't see any — I worked more when I put out my first album on Beamtide, my label, with Jack DeJohnette and Eddie Gomez, "Double Entendre." I worked for a year and a half on that album all over the country, all over the world, and yet with the albums on labels things weren't really that great, no. I don't know. As I say, I think as the quality goes down the singers of quality or the musicians of quality have a harder time because the level is so low that everybody can do it.

MR: Right. Well not everybody can do what you do.

TL: Thanks, Monk.

MR: Well anyway, it's been a great pleasure talking with you.

TL: Oh, thank you, man. A pleasure, totally.

MR: Right.